BoF Session Guide
GenAI Usage and Burden

Purpose
This guide adapts the pyOpenSci 1:1 maintainer interview effort into a conference Birds of a Feather session. The goal stays the same, understanding GenAI related behaviours well enough to eventually propose guidelines, but the mechanism changes to small group discussion at themed tables, since the organizer will not personally talk with everyone in the room.

How to use this guide
This document has two parts. The first part, the pages you are reading now, is for you as the session organizer: purpose, timing, room setup, and shared doc setup. The second part is a set of theme cards, one per page, meant to be printed and handed to each table's volunteer facilitator. The themes are defined in a separate file so they can be swapped out without touching anything else in this guide.

Run of show
Target 45 minutes, expected to run to 60. Only the breakout discussion block is elastic. Everything else stays fixed regardless of overrun.

Segment	Time	Content
Welcome and framing	5 min	Purpose of the session, why pyOpenSci is looking at this, a short framing of patterns already observed. [Insert current pattern data or observations here before the session. Do not present placeholder numbers as real.]
Group formation and instructions	3 min	Point out the four themed tables, explain self-selection, facilitators introduce themselves, quick note on the shared doc and QR code. State clearly that this session is not about debugging anyone's specific tool setup, it is about honest experience.
Breakout discussion	27 min, flexes to 40 or more	Themed tables run their question set with their facilitator, logging notes into the shared doc live. This is the block that absorbs the 45 to 60 minute overrun. If running long, cut here. If running short, add here.
Facilitator highlights	5 min	Each of the four facilitators gives one short spoken highlight from their table, instead of hearing from every attendee, so the room gets a cross section without a full share-back.

Segment	Time	Content
Closing	3 min	Thanks, reminder that notes live in the shared doc, stay-involved QR code or link.

Room setup and group formation

No dedicated table signage is needed. Each facilitator's printed theme card doubles as the table marker, held up or placed on the table during the framing segment. After instructions, attendees self-select by walking to whichever themed table interests them most.

If a table grows past about 10 to 12 people, the facilitator splits into two clusters within the same theme, pooling notes under the same shared doc heading rather than attempting one large-group conversation.

Shared doc and stay involved

Before the session, create a single Google Doc for the whole room. Give it one heading per theme, matching the theme cards, plus a stay-involved section at the top with a survey or mailing list link. Set sharing so anyone with the link can comment or edit, and generate a QR code for that link.

Show the QR code during framing and again at closing. It covers both live note taking during the session and the post session survey signup, so attendees only need to scan once.

QR CODE
PLACEHOLDER

Shared doc link: ____

Theme cards

The following pages are the theme cards. Print and hand one to each facilitator. Themes are defined in `_bof-themes.qmd` and can be changed there without editing anything above this line.

Theme: Motivations and perceptions

Why this theme: understanding why people adopt or avoid GenAI tools, and how they honestly feel about them, not just how often they use them.

Questions:

- What led people at this table to start using GenAI tools in their open source work? What has kept others from adopting them?
- When you do use these tools, what are you actually gaining? Not how often, but what the value is.
- What are your honest feelings about these tools in your role, whether that is maintaining, contributing, or reviewing?
- Does everyone at this table feel the same way about this, or is there real disagreement here?

Facilitator probe: is there a gap between what people think they are supposed to feel about these tools and what they actually feel day to day?

Time budget: if short on time, prioritize the gaining and value question and the disagreement question.

Log in the shared doc: the range of views at the table, especially where people disagreed, not just the average.

Theme: Burden and strain

Why this theme: understanding where GenAI is adding burden to open source work, and where it might be relieving it, especially for maintainers and reviewers.

Questions:

- Where has GenAI added burden to the open source work represented at this table? Where has it relieved burden?
- Has anyone reviewed a contribution they suspected was AI assisted? What was that like?
- How much of the strain people feel, if any, gets attributed to GenAI related changes versus everything else going on?
- Is there a specific moment or incident anyone at this table wants to share that stands out as particularly stressful?

Facilitator probe: this can be a hard thing to say out loud in a group. Remind the table that notes are captured thematically, not attributed to individuals by name.

Time budget: if short on time, prioritize the burden versus relief question and any specific incident.

Log in the shared doc: specific incidents in general terms, patterns across the table, and any strong disagreement about how much GenAI itself is responsible for the strain.

Theme: Perfect world and desired change

Why this theme: understanding what maintainers and contributors would want to see change, given that these tools exist and are not going away.

Questions:

- In a perfect world, what would GenAI assisted contributions to open source projects look like?
- What is the one thing that, if changed, would most reduce burden for people at this table?
- What would this table need, from tools, from the community, or from other maintainers, to feel less strained?
- If this table could send one message to every contributor using GenAI to submit to open source projects, what would it be?

Facilitator probe: push past "better tools" as an answer. What specifically would a better tool or norm do differently?

Time budget: if short on time, prioritize the one thing that would help question and the one message question.

Log in the shared doc: concrete, specific answers, not just "less burden" or "better review." Specificity is what turns into guidelines later.

Theme: AI-generated contribution quality

Why this theme: understanding the reviewer side burden of AI-generated or AI-assisted contributions, and how maintainers and editorial processes are handling it.

Questions:

- How does this table currently tell, or guess, when a contribution was AI generated or AI assisted?
- How has the volume of AI-influenced contributions changed for people at this table, compared to a year or two ago?
- Does triage or review process differ for these versus other contributions? How?
- Has anyone at this table dealt with a low quality or hallucinated AI-generated submission? What happened?

Facilitator probe: ask whether this shows up differently in code contributions versus other kinds of submissions, like JOSE reviews or documentation.

Time budget: if short on time, prioritize the triage difference question and any specific incident.

Log in the shared doc: any concrete detection strategies or triage practices mentioned. These are the most directly reusable for guidelines.

Closing

Read or paraphrase:

"Thank you all so much for the honest conversation today. Everything your table discussed has been captured in the shared doc, and we will be using it, alongside the 1:1 interviews we are running separately, to understand what is actually going on and start proposing guidelines that reduce burden rather than add to it.

If you want to stay involved, scan the code or use the link to join the survey, sprint, or focus group mailing list. We will follow up once this is written up."